Paris Travel Guide

The City of Light on the River Seine - France

Paris: Overview and History

Paris is the capital of France and sits on the River Seine in the north of the country. The city began as a settlement of a Celtic tribe called the Parisii, and after the Roman conquest it became the Roman town of Lutetia. Like London, Barcelona and Istanbul, Paris was once part of the Roman Empire, whose capital was Rome.

During the Middle Ages Paris grew into one of the largest cities in Europe, and the Gothic cathedral of Notre-Dame was built on the Ile de la Cite. The French Revolution began here in 1789 with the storming of the Bastille. In the nineteenth century Baron Haussmann redesigned the city with the wide boulevards and cream-coloured apartment buildings that visitors see today.

Paris is nicknamed the City of Light because it was an early adopter of street lighting and a centre of the Enlightenment. Today it is famous for art, fashion, food and romance, and it hosted the Summer Olympic Games in 1900, 1924 and 2024. The city is divided into 20 numbered districts called arrondissements that spiral outwards from the centre like a snail shell.

Paris has a special link with New York: the Statue of Liberty was a gift from France to the United States. It was designed by the French sculptor Frederic Auguste Bartholdi, and its internal iron framework was engineered by Gustave Eiffel, the same engineer whose company built the Eiffel Tower. A smaller replica of the statue stands on the Ile aux Cygnes in Paris.

Paris: Top Attractions

The Eiffel Tower is the symbol of Paris. It was built by the company of Gustave Eiffel for the Exposition Universelle (World's Fair) of 1889 and is about 330 metres tall. Visitors can climb the stairs to the second floor or take lifts to the summit. The tower sparkles with lights for five minutes every hour after dark. The Tokyo Tower in Japan was later inspired by its design.

The Louvre is the most visited museum in the world and a former royal palace. Its collection includes the Mona Lisa by Leonardo da Vinci, the Venus de Milo and the Winged Victory of Samothrace. The glass pyramid entrance was designed by the architect I. M. Pei and opened in 1989. The Louvre also lent its name to the Louvre Abu Dhabi near Dubai, which opened in 2017.

Notre-Dame Cathedral was badly damaged by a fire in April 2019 and reopened to visitors in December 2024 after a huge restoration. The Musee d'Orsay, housed in a former railway station, holds the world's greatest collection of Impressionist art, including works by Monet, Renoir and Van Gogh.

Other highlights include the Arc de Triomphe at the top of the Champs-Elysees, the white Sacre-Coeur Basilica on the hill of Montmartre, the stained glass of Sainte-Chapelle, and the Luxembourg Gardens. A boat cruise on the Seine is a relaxing way to see many monuments in one hour.

Paris: Neighborhoods and Food

Le Marais is a historic district of narrow medieval streets, elegant mansions and the Place des Vosges, the oldest planned square in Paris. Rue des Rosiers in the Marais is famous for falafel. Montmartre, on a hill in the north, was home to artists such as Picasso and Van Gogh, and painters still work in the Place du Tertre.

Saint-Germain-des-Pres on the Left Bank is known for literary cafes such as Cafe de Flore and Les Deux Magots, where writers like Jean-Paul Sartre and Simone de Beauvoir worked. The Latin Quarter, around the Sorbonne university, is lively with students, bookshops and cheap restaurants.

French food is a highlight of any visit. Start the day with a buttery croissant or pain au chocolat and a cafe creme. Lunch might be a jambon-beurre sandwich on a fresh baguette, and dinner at a bistro could be steak frites, duck confit or French onion soup. Paris is also famous for crepes, cheese, and colourful macarons from patisseries such as Laduree and Pierre Herme.

Food markets such as the Marche des Enfants Rouges, the oldest covered market in Paris, are great places for lunch. In France a service charge is included in restaurant bills ('service compris'), so tipping is optional; leaving small change for good service is appreciated.

Paris: Getting Around and Practical Tips

The Paris Metro is one of the densest subway networks in the world, with 16 lines and over 300 stations, so almost every address is within a short walk of a station. A single Metro ticket costs around 2.50 euros, and visitors staying a week can buy a Navigo weekly pass. The RER suburban trains connect the centre with the airports and with Versailles.

Paris has two main airports. Charles de Gaulle Airport (CDG) is linked to the city centre by the RER B train in about 35 minutes, and Orly Airport is served by the Orlyval shuttle and Metro line 14. The currency in Paris is the euro (EUR), and cards are accepted almost everywhere.

The Eurostar high-speed train connects Paris Gare du Nord with London St Pancras International through the Channel Tunnel in about 2 hours and 15 minutes. High-speed TGV trains also run from Paris Gare de Lyon to Barcelona in about six and a half hours, making Paris a great base for a multi-city European trip.

The best time to visit Paris is in spring, from April to June, when the parks bloom, or in early autumn in September and October. July and August are hot and crowded, and many small shops close in August. Museums are often closed on Monday or Tuesday, so check before you go.

Paris: Sample Itinerary and Day Trips

Day 1: Start at the Eiffel Tower in the morning, walk across the Seine to the Trocadero for the classic photo, then take a Seine river cruise. In the evening walk up the Champs-Elysees to the Arc de Triomphe. Day 2: Spend the morning in the Louvre, have lunch in the Marais, then visit Notre-Dame and Sainte-Chapelle on the Ile de la Cite.

Day 3: Explore Montmartre and the Sacre-Coeur in the morning, then visit the Musee d'Orsay in the afternoon, and finish with dinner in Saint-Germain-des-Pres.

The most popular day trip is the Palace of Versailles, the lavish home of King Louis XIV, which is about 40 minutes away on the RER C train. Art lovers can visit Giverny to see Claude Monet's house and water-lily garden. Fast TGV trains reach Reims, the heart of the Champagne region, in about 45 minutes, and the island abbey of Mont-Saint-Michel can be reached on a long day trip.

Travellers on a bigger European adventure often combine Paris with London by Eurostar, or with Barcelona by TGV.